Six Best Practice Tips for Gathering Feedback on Your Prototypes

Gathering feedback is a crucial element in the design thinking process as well as all other human-centered design processes. To maximize the benefits of gathering feedback, however, you need to be purposeful about it. Here are some pointers to take note of when you gather feedback from your users.

1. Think of How to Solicit Feedback

How you solicit feedback from your users (or team-mates, if you are doing preliminary tests within your team) depends largely on what type of prototype you have built. For instance, if your prototype is a paper interface, you'll need to conduct in-person tests with users and guide them through the process of using the prototype to gather feedback. Nevertheless, there are some general rules of thumb you can rely on to solicit better feedback.

First, consider testing **several versions of your prototype**. This helps to solicit critical feedback, because people tend to hold back on overtly criticizing prototypes. When you present your users with alternatives, you allow them to compare the various prototypes and tell you what they liked and disliked about each version, so you will get more honest feedback.

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You can also use the **"I Like, I Wish, What If"** method to solicit honest feedback in test sessions. This method helps your users to voice their opinions in a critical but positive manner.

2. Test Your Prototypes on the Right People

To get the best results, you need to **test on the right people**. If you are in the early stages of your design project and just want some simple and rough feedback, it's good enough to test on your team-mates. However, towards the end of your project, when you create more detailed prototypes, you should test on a representative sample of users to get the most relevant feedback.

On top of regular users, you can also **test on extreme users**. This helps you uncover problems that affect regular users, because extreme users tend to be more vocal about their love (or hate) of doing things related to your prototype. To find extreme users, you need to define a dimension relevant to your prototype. If you're working on an idea related to supermarkets, for example, your extreme users could be people who shop at supermarkets every day, and (on the other end of the scale) people who never shop at supermarkets.

If your product or service serves an international audience, you should also test your prototypes across **regions and countries**. Different cultures and customs might affect how people use your prototype.

Towards the final stages of your project, you should also get feedback on your prototypes from **stakeholders** other than your users. Internal stakeholders, manufacturers, retailers and distributors each have their own criteria for building, making or shipping your product, and can have an impact on your solution's success. When you gather feedback from these stakeholders, you'll prevent your team from receiving a nasty shock when you realize that you can't implement the product as feasibly as you had believed.

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3. Ask the Right Questions

Each prototype that you test **should answer a few core questions**. Before you test your prototypes, you should therefore figure out what exactly you want to test. For example, if you want to assess your product's usability, then you should create tasks for users to complete to test how easy your solution is to use. Subsequently, in a post-testing interview with your user, you should focus on positive and negative feedback relating to usability.

At the same time, **keep an open mind** when you test your prototypes, even though you have a few questions you want to answer. Many times, test sessions can reveal key points on issues that your team did not even know to focus on. After testing, you should evaluate the feedback and decide if there are new questions that you should ask during future test sessions.

4. Be Neutral When You Present Your Ideas

When you present your prototypes to your users, **be as objective as you can**. Refrain from trying to sell your idea. Remember that the goal of prototyping and testing is to find ways to improve your idea. When you over-sell your idea, you're likely to reduce the likelihood of receiving accurate feedback.

Refrain from defending your prototype when your users voice negative feedback. Instead, probe them further to find out what exactly is wrong with your solution. Don't get too attached to your idea, and always be ready to dismantle, change or even abandon it when you need to. Remember, this stage is like a rehearsal, not the real "show"; you're *not* being cut to pieces in the marketplace—in fact, when you make careful corrections that stem from negative feedback, you'll greatly help your chances of success later on.

5. Adapt While You Test

Adopt a flexible mindset when you test your prototypes. For instance, if you realize that users keep getting distracted by a nonessential part of your prototype, you can remove it to bring the focus back to the key elements of your prototype. In addition, if you think your script for the test session does not work well, feel free to deviate from it to get the best feedback from your users.

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Even though you should adapt while you test, be aware that you shouldn't change things up with every test session. Be flexible within reason. After all, you need to perform the same test on multiple users to get an accurate picture of how well your prototype works with the *average* user. If you change things up in every test—for example, if you change your prototype or your script in each test—you'll find it difficult to compare the results of different test sessions.

6. Let Your Users Contribute Ideas

During your test session, **allow your users to contribute ideas** to improve your prototypes. You can ask your users how the product or service could be improved, for example. Doing so would encourage users to provide useful critiques as well as help improve your solution.

You can also turn some questions that your users ask during the tests around—and ask the users what *they* think. For example, if your user asks you how to charge an electronic device, turn it around to ask them what *they think* would be the best charging method for the product. Even if you don't adopt their ideas, you'll get some insight about their key areas of concern.

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